

traveling in the opposite direction. Chinese inventions ranging from gunpowder and paper to the magnetic compass were also brought to the west along the route, arriving at Constantinople and the Black Sea ports, the western end of the route where Genoa and Venice chiefly traded.

Mongol revival of the route

By the 13th century, empires that had controlled sections of the Silk Road had fragmented. This left the route less secure for travelers, and so deterred merchants from using it. However, following Mongol conquest of the area between 1205 and 1269, the area was controlled—if loosely—by a single authority, the Great Khan, so a merchant could travel from Khanbaliq (Beijing) to Baghdad without leaving Mongol territory. This renewed stability encouraged a revival of trade.

At around this time, European merchants' horizons were also expanding. In the early Middle Ages, traders could work only locally, and transport their goods to points where they might connect to longer distance trade routes. From the 12th century, Italian city-states such as Pisa, Genoa, and Venice, pioneered maritime trade across the eastern Mediterranean, which enabled merchants to connect directly with sea routes that linked West Asia and Egypt to China via the Indian Ocean.

The profits for merchants taking advantage of the "Pax Mongolica," or Mongol peace, could be huge. In the late 13th century, the costs of setting up a caravan might amount to 3,500 florins, but the cargo, once sold in China, could yield seven times that sum, and by 1326 Genoese traders were a common sight in the principal Chinese port of Zaiton.

Decline of land trade

The Silk Road flourished for a further century, but the collapse of the Mongol Ilkhanate of Persia in 1335, and the overthrow in 1368 of the Yuan, the Mongol ruling dynasty in China, once again left the route divided between politically weak powers. It was also blocked to European traders at the western end by the growth of the Muslim Ottoman Empire.

A taste of the profits of long-distance trade in luxury goods encouraged European powers to seek alternatives to the now defunct Silk Road, this time by sea. In 1514, Portuguese merchants arrived off the coast of China, near Guangzhou, eager to take up the direct trading links with China that had been pioneered two and a half centuries earlier by their illustrious predecessor, Marco Polo. ■



Marco Polo

At just 17 years old, Marco Polo (1254–1324) set off from Venice to the court of the Mongol ruler, Kublai Khan. He traveled with his father and uncle, who had previously visited China and been entrusted by Kublai with a message for the pope. Polo was received with great favor at the Mongol court and stayed in China for 17 years. He traveled extensively throughout the country in the Khan's service, leaving for home at last in around 1291.

During a naval battle in 1298, Polo was captured and imprisoned by the Genoese. The stories he told of his sojourn in the lands of the Great Khan attracted the attention of his cell mate, Rustichello, who wrote them down, embellishing them as he went along. The resulting book was translated into many languages and includes much invaluable information about late-13th-century China. After his release, Polo returned to Venice, where he lived for the rest of his life.